

Victor Horta and Hector Guimard

The townhouse Hôtel Tassel in Brussels was the first building conceived fully in the art nouveau style. Rather than hide structural elements, Belgian Victor Horta (1861–1947) used them as decoration; cast iron, for instance, appears in the form of plant-like tendrils snaking through the building. Horta was influenced by Viollet-le-Duc's maxim that machine-made materials be used to create 'architectural forms adapted to our time'. He exploited iron's load-bearing strength to make wide spans, maximising internal space as well as daylight.

Hector Guimard (1867–1942) designed his Métro entrances to coincide with the 1900 Universal Exposition in Paris. Built in iron, glass and green steel, they are filled with light, and stress organic, asymmetrical, delicate decoration. Such was their impact, art nouveau in France was sometimes called *Guimard style* or *style Métro* – even though they were criticized at the time. His own Paris home, Hôtel Guimard (1912), stands on a triangular plot and features curved walls and flowing forms.



Hotel Tassel in Brussels, Horta, 1893